

I'll narrow to 1200–1299 only. The likely hard core is not Aokigahara suicide material — it is the medieval Fuji cave/underworld layer, especially Hitoana in 1203, plus what can and cannot be said about Saiko/Shōji/Aokigahara in that century.

Thought for 29s >

Thirteenth century only — **1200–1299** — gives one genuinely major answer:

Aokigahara itself is still almost silent, but Fuji's cave-underworld imagination becomes documentarily visible in 1203 through the Hitoana episode in *Azuma Kagami*.



That is the century's hard centre. Not suicide. Not “樹海”. Not Matsumoto. Not modern disappearance. The thirteenth century gives us something older and stranger: **Fuji as a mountain whose subterranean lava spaces are already imagined as sacred, dangerous, otherworldly, and potentially fatal.**

The precise answer is:

In the thirteenth century, the later Aokigahara death-imaginary does not yet exist as such. What exists is a medieval Fuji cave-imaginary: human entry into a lava cavity, darkness, bats, an underground river, supernatural vision, sudden deaths, return from the underworld, and the identification of the cave as the dwelling-place of Sengen/Asama divinity.

That is the root. Not suicide. **Underworld cave encounter.**

1. The century's source base is brutally narrow

For 1200–1299, the available evidence is not broad. There is no thirteenth-century “Aokigahara suicide forest” dossier. There is no thirteenth-century *Nami no Tō* equivalent. There is no premodern police record, no local “suicide hotspot” register, no stable public phrase “青木ヶ原樹海” doing later work.

The century gives us mainly:

1203 — the Hitoana episode in *Azuma Kagami*;

the wider Kamakura-period shift of Fuji from remote volcanic deity to mountain/cave religious site;

the early medieval formation of Fuji as a place of ascent and ascetic practice;

later medieval/early modern reworking of the Hitoana episode into *Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi*.

So the thirteenth-century answer has to be precise: the strongest material is **not Aokigahara proper**, but **Fuji's west/north-west lava-cave sacred geography**.

2. 1203 is the key date

The core event is recorded in *Azuma Kagami*. During Minamoto no Yoriie's Fuji hunting excursion, Nitta/Nita Tadatsune was ordered to investigate **Hitoana**, a lava cave at Fuji's western foot.

Shizuoka's official cultural-property page says that in Ken'nin 3, 1203, Nitta Tadatsune reported that Hitoana was extremely narrow, difficult to move through, dark, full of many bats, and that there was a great river deeper inside. The same page identifies Hitoana as a place treated as the residence of Fuji Sengen Daibosatsu.  Shizuoka Prefe...

Fujinomiya's official site gives the same structural point: *Azuma Kagami* describes the Hitoana exploration, and the story was later gathered as a Sengen/Asama Daibosatsu miracle-tale in **Hitoana Sōshi**; it also says *Azuma Kagami* records Hitoana as the “御在所” of Asama Daibosatsu, showing that the cave was already connected to Fuji faith at that time.  Fujinomiya City

That is the century's hard documentary nucleus.

3. What actually happens in the Hitoana story

The compressed version is not enough. The details matter.

Kotobank's entry on Nitta Tadatsune, drawing on the older encyclopaedic account, says that on 3 June 1203, during Yoriie's Fuji hunt, Nitta Shiro Tadatsune entered Fuji's Hitoana with six men. Inside, there was an underground river with waves surging backwards; when they illuminated the far side with torches, they saw something extraordinary or uncanny. Four retainers died suddenly. Tadatsune threw into the river a sword he had received from the shogun and eventually returned the next day. The account adds that old people said the cave was the dwelling-place of Asama Daibosatsu.  コトバンク

This is not a casual cave anecdote. It contains almost every component of an underworld descent:

entry into a narrow dark opening;
animal signs — bats;
difficulty moving forward;
a river boundary;
a vision across the river;
fatal consequence;
ritual offering or surrender of a sword;

return from forbidden depth;
local elders interpreting the place as divine residence.

That structure matters more than any later “suicide forest” cliché.

4. This is not Aokigahara, but it is the same deep grammar

Hitoana is on Fuji’s western foot, not the later central Aokigahara/Lake Saiko suicide zone.
So we must not conflate them.

But it is absolutely relevant because it proves that, by 1203, Fuji’s lava-cave landscape could already be imagined as an **entrance into a dangerous sacred otherworld**.

The later Aokigahara imaginary also depends on entry into a non-ordinary natural space.
But the 1203 grammar is different:

1203: warrior enters sacred cave → sees otherworld signs → death/terror occurs → cave is divine residence.

20th century: distressed person enters forest → seeks quiet disappearance → body may not be found.

The continuity is **entry into non-ordinary Fuji nature**.

The discontinuity is the purpose: **religious terror and divine encounter**, not private self-erasure.

5. The underground river is the decisive image

The most important image is not the bats. It is the river.

A river inside a cave is not just geography in a medieval tale. It functions like a boundary between worlds. The Kotobank summary says Tadatsune and his men came to a great river with violent or backwards-surging waves, and the vision occurred beyond it.

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That is why this source matters for the long history of Aokigahara/Fuji death-imagery. A person enters Fuji’s lava interior and meets a boundary he cannot cross. Across it is something supernatural. Crossing or seeing too much is fatal.

This is a much older structure than “suicide forest”:

Fuji’s underground is not empty. It is guarded, sacred, dangerous, and not fully available to human knowledge.

Aokigahara’s later power is partly a forest version of that: the interior is imagined as a place where ordinary social mapping fails.

6. The deaths in the story are not suicide deaths

This must be stated cleanly.

The thirteenth-century deaths are not voluntary self-killing. They are deaths caused by contact with a forbidden or sacred space. They belong to the grammar of **taboo, divine danger, and otherworld trespass**.

That is crucial. If you are tracing “the forest in relation to death”, the thirteenth century gives death, but of the wrong kind for the modern myth.

It is not:

“I go there to die.”

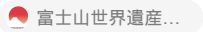
It is:

“To enter too far into Fuji’s hidden interior may be deadly.”

That is a completely different cultural mechanism.

7. The century’s deepest Japanese-culture layer: Fuji is becoming more than a volcano

The Hitoana episode sits inside a larger transformation.

The Yamanashi Fujisan World Heritage Center says early Fuji faith began with fear of eruptions and distant worship, but when eruptions calmed, religious practitioners began treating Fuji as a mountain of ascetic practice. It specifically says that in the twelfth century, Matsu-dai/Shōdai — usually rendered as Matsudai — climbed Fuji more than a hundred times and founded Fuji-san Kōbōji, creating a Fuji Shugendō group; from the fourteenth century, lay believers called **dōja** appeared. 

For the thirteenth century, that means we are in the intermediate zone:

older eruption-fear is not gone;
ascetic/mountain practice is forming;
cave and summit spaces are gaining religious intensity;
lay mass pilgrimage has not yet fully arrived.

So the thirteenth-century Fuji world is not yet Edo Fuji-kō and not yet modern tourism. It is **medieval sacred danger**.

8. The thirteenth century’s directional logic: inward/downward, not yet forest-horizontal

The thirteenth-century Hitoana story is not an ascent story in the way later Fuji pilgrimage becomes. It is a descent or inward-entry story.

That matters because the broader Fuji tradition has two axes:

vertical axis: climb the mountain, approach summit, seek salvation/rebirth;

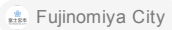
inward axis: enter cave, encounter hidden divine/underworld presence.

The fourteenth/fifteenth-century route evidence is mainly vertical ascent. The thirteenth-century Hitoana evidence is inward descent.

Aokigahara's later death-imaginary is closer to the inward axis than the summit axis. The person does not climb to salvation. They enter a dark, enclosing Fuji landscape.

But again: in 1203, the inward axis is **sacred/terrifying**; in modern Aokigahara, it becomes **psychological/social disappearance**.

9. “御在所” is a crucial word

The official Fujinomiya page says *Azuma Kagami* treats Hitoana as the 御在所 of Asama Daibosatsu. 

That word matters. It means the cave is not merely a “scary hole”. It is a dwelling-place or seat of the deity. This is what converts landscape into sacred geography.

So the thirteenth-century thought is not:

“this cave is haunted.”

It is closer to:

“this cave is where the Fuji deity is present.”

The danger is not random horror. It is proximity to divine power.

10. Why this is not yet Aokigahara

Aokigahara, as later imagined, requires several things that are not present here:

a named “tree sea” reputation;

a public no-return forest label;

a modern media system;

transport from urban centres;

a secular psychology of self-erasure;

newspaper contagion;

Matsumoto's vanishing scene;

Tsurumi/manual/internet afterlives;
modern police/rescue infrastructure.

None of that belongs to the thirteenth century.

The thirteenth-century material is not a primitive version of the same thing. It is a different religious structure that later can be re-used.

11. What is Aokigahara itself doing in the thirteenth century?

Physically, the forest is there. By 1200, the Jōgan lava flow is more than three centuries old. The later Saiko/Shōji lake configuration already exists. The lava forest is growing over rough basalt, with caves, moss, shallow soil, and difficult footing.

But source-wise, Aokigahara itself is mostly background. The named thirteenth-century evidence clusters at Hitoana and the Fuji sacred complex, not at the Saiko/Aokigahara forest interior.

So the correct sentence is:

In the thirteenth century, Aokigahara exists as part of the Fuji lava-foot environment, but the surviving cultural record names the cave and mountain system more clearly than the forest.

That is why any answer pretending to give a rich thirteenth-century Aokigahara social history would be overclaiming.

12. The later *Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi* proves the 1203 story had afterlife

The 1203 Hitoana episode did not just sit inert in *Azuma Kagami*. It became literary/religious material.

Kotobank's entry on **Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi** says it is an otogizōshi tale, probably already formed by the fifteenth century because a 1527 diary entry mentions "fuji no hitoana no monogatari". It says the work uses the *Azuma Kagami* entries about cave explorations and turns them into a story of otherworld visitation and hell-circuit narrative, probably used in Fuji faith preaching. 

NDL's bibliographic record for a 1661 printed *Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi* says the story has Nitta Shiro Tadatsuna enter Hitoana, be guided by Fuji Sengen Daigongen through hell and paradise, receive a scroll, and return with a warning about speaking of what he saw.

This matters because it shows how the 1203 cave report was metabolised. It was not remembered merely as exploration. It became **underworld literature**.

But again, that afterlife is later than the thirteenth century. Use it as reception-history, not as direct 1203 evidence.

13. The thirteenth-century core is not “forest”; it is “cave”

This is the cleanest formulation.

The later Aokigahara discourse is arboreal: trees, roots, moss, bodies lost in woods, forest paths, no return.

The thirteenth-century Fuji death/otherworld discourse is speleological: cave, darkness, bats, subterranean river, supernatural sight, sudden death, divine residence.

So the century's grammar is:

穴, not 樹海.

Cave, not tree sea.

Underworld opening, not forest maze.

That is a major historical distinction.

14. The 1203 event as “controlled transgression”

The Hitoana entry is also politically interesting.

Tadatsune does not enter because he is a pilgrim seeking salvation or a despairing person seeking death. He enters because the shogun orders an exploration during a hunting event. That gives the episode a worldly, warrior-aristocratic frame.

So the structure is:

elite command;

warrior obedience;

penetration of forbidden terrain;

failure of normal military masculinity before sacred geography;

return with supernatural knowledge.

This is not a suicide script. It is a **Kamakura warrior encounter with a sacred limit**.

That is probably the deepest social meaning of the source: the military regime can command entry into terrain, but cannot master the otherworld inside Fuji.

15. How this relates to Japanese people/discourse at the deepest level

For the thirteenth century, the key Japanese cultural relation is not “the forest attracts suicidal people”. It is:

Fuji’s hidden spaces are not inert nature. They are inhabited, morally charged, and dangerous to penetrate.

This is a wider medieval Japanese pattern: mountains, caves, springs and remote interiors are not neutral scenic objects. They are contact zones with kami, buddhas, spirits, hells, Pure Lands, or taboo forces. Hitoana is a precise Fuji example.

Aokigahara later inherits some of this because it is not a normal forest. It sits on Fuji lava, near caves, beside old lake-worlds, under a mountain already saturated with sacred fear.

But the thirteenth-century “death” is **contact with the sacred**, not modern self-destruction.

16. The decisive negative finding

No reliable accessible thirteenth-century material I found says:

Aokigahara was used for suicide;

Aokigahara was a corpse forest;

Aokigahara was an ubasute place;

people travelled there to disappear;

locals treated the forest as a death destination;

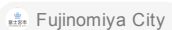
the phrase “樹海” had the later modern suicide meaning.

So the answer must not pretend otherwise.

The thirteenth century gives **underworld cave genealogy**, not suicide-site genealogy.

17. What the thirteenth century contributes to the later Aokigahara myth

It contributes three elements.

First, **Fuji lava interiors can be otherworld gates**. Hitoana proves that in a thirteenth-century text. 

Second, **entry can be fatal or spiritually dangerous**. Tadatsune’s retainers die; the cave is not ordinary terrain. 

Third, **the hidden interior is narratable**. The 1203 episode later becomes *Hitoana Sōshi*, a preaching/otherworld tale. 

Those are deep preconditions. They do not explain modern suicide by themselves. But they show why Fuji's hidden interiors could carry more weight than mere geography.

18. The exact thirteenth-century source hierarchy

For 1200–1299, the sources rank like this.

1. *Azuma Kagami*, 1203 Hitoana episode — the core source. Preserved/quoted in official cultural-property summaries and encyclopaedic entries; it gives the cave, bats, underground river, deaths, return, and divine-residence interpretation.

 Shizuoka Prefe... +1

2. Fujinomiya official Hitoana Fuji-kō site page — best concise official interpretation: *Azuma Kagami* → Hitoana as Asama Daibosatsu's residence → later Hitoana Sōshi and Fuji-kō spread.  Fujinomiya City

3. Yamanashi/Fuji World Heritage faith-history pages — best broader frame: Fuji shifts from eruption-fear/distant worship into ascetic mountain practice, with lay ascent developing later.  富士山世界遺産...

4. *Fuji no Hitoana Sōshi* reception materials — not thirteenth-century evidence directly, but proof that the 1203 episode became a major medieval/early modern underworld narrative.  コトバンク +1

5. Aokigahara geological/lake background — necessary physical setting, but not thirteenth-century cultural evidence for suicide or death. Use only as background.

Final thirteenth-century thesis

In the thirteenth century, Aokigahara is not yet the death forest. It is not yet the “sea of trees” as modern Japanese discourse knows it. The forest exists physically, but the surviving cultural record gives the power to Fuji's cave-world, especially Hitoana.

The century's decisive event is the 1203 *Azuma Kagami* Hitoana exploration: a Kamakura warrior enters Fuji's lava cave under shogunal command, meets darkness, bats, an underground river, supernatural terror, deaths among his companions, and the cave's identification as the dwelling-place of Asama/Sengen divinity. That is the earliest strong documentary layer for Fuji's hidden interior as a sacred and deadly threshold.

So the precise answer is:

The thirteenth-century root of Aokigahara's later death-imaginary is not suicide. It is the medieval Fuji cave-underworld: the idea that entering Fuji's hidden lava interior means crossing into a space where ordinary human mastery fails, the divine is present, and return is uncertain.

Later Aokigahara will secularise and forest-translate that structure. The cave becomes the forest. Divine danger becomes psychological disappearance. Warrior descent becomes solitary entry. Otherworld river becomes no-return woodland. But in the thirteenth century itself, the grammar is still sacred, not suicidal; cave, not tree sea; forbidden encounter, not self-erasure.